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When Perfumers Play Dermatologist

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Prestige beauty rewards brand equity before expertise. The result is a market in which fragrance houses can drift into skincare. while the people who understand the science must prove themselves twice.

There is a particular arrogance in the fragrance industry's expansion into skincare. A confidence utterly unearned by expertise, clinical trials, or any demonstrated understanding of dermatological science. These are houses built on smelling nice.

They have been selling products that go on your skin for years, and in some cases decades. Byredo has been making body lotions, creams and soaps since 2010. Which raises the obvious question of what they learned in that time, and the answer, on the evidence of the labels, is nothing that changed a formulation.

Byredo provides the most instructive example of this hubris. Founded in 2006 by
Ben Gorham. A former professional basketball player with a degree in fine art. The Swedish brand built its reputation on fragrances with evocative names and minimalist packaging. Gypsy Water. Mojave Ghost. Products that smell interesting and photograph well for Instagram.



In 2021, Forbes asked Gorham directly whether he planned to expand Byredo beyond fragrance and colour cosmetics. His answer is worth reading in full:

"Definitely. We'd probably look at skincare as kind of a third axis. I think about it. But I also think about another 10 categories [that are] completely random... leather goods, apparel and accessories, furniture, ceramics and eyewear."
Ben Gorham, Founder of Byredo[34]

A third axis. Named in the same breath as ceramics and eyewear, as one of ten categories that might just as easily have been something else.
Not: we have identified an unmet clinical need.
Not: we have hired dermatologists.
Not: we have anything to offer that the category lacks.

Skincare here is a slot on a grid. A place to put the brand next and the fact that it goes on people's faces rather than their feet is incidental to the decision.

Gorham has now departed Byredo entirely, three years after Puig's acquisition valued the brand at approximately €1 billion. What he left behind is a range with no dermatologist on record and no published clinical trials and, on the evidence of the labels, no consistent view of what the products are for. The washes are competently built. The hand creams lead with shea butter and then place denatured alcohol sixth or seventh, ahead of the glycerin, in a product designed to stay on the skin. [33] Somebody in that building knew which ingredients repair a barrier. Somebody else, in the same building, chose the one that dissolves it. Nobody appears to have been responsible for noticing.

This pattern repeats across the prestige fragrance landscape. Le Labo, owned by Estée Lauder since 2014, sells face lotions, body creams and grooming products. Sodium lauryl sulfate leads the surfactant system in its shower gels and shampoos. A choice the wider industry has spent two decades retreating from. The leave-on products are better made. But a house that can specify shea butter and squalane for a face lotion and still reaches for SLS in the wash is not making an error of knowledge. It is deciding which product has to perform and which one only has to foam.[35]

For Black consumers, this isn't merely disappointing; it's potentially harmful. It's potentially harmful. Melanin-rich skin does not answer irritation the way lighter skin does. Where one produces transient redness, the other produces pigment that can take months to clear. That single difference changes what an ill-considered formulation costs and it is precisely the thing a house extending from fragrance into skincare has no reason to know and no obligation to find out.

When a basketball player decides his fragrance brand should sell face cream to reach a billion-dollar revenue target, none of these considerations enter the equation. When a perfume house extends into body lotion because the margins are attractive, testing across Fitzpatrick skin types isn't the priority. The priority is leveraging existing brand awareness into adjacent categories.

> **A perfumer's job is to compose scents. A dermatologist's job is to understand skin. When perfumers start selling skincare without dermatologists, the result is expensive-smelling products that may actively damage the skin of consumers who trusted the brand's prestige to mean something. That isn't luxury. That's negligence with good marketing.**

Case Study: The Elephant in the Room

In 2009, a woman in Houston, Texas, started selling soap.

This is not, on its face, a remarkable thing. People sell soap all the time. But Tiffany Masterson was not a cosmetic chemist. She was not a dermatologist. She had not spent years in pharmaceutical research or studied the behaviour of active ingredients on human skin. From 2000 to 2009, Masterson had been a stay-at-home mother of four. Before that, she had worked in real estate alongside her mother, then at Neiman Marcus, then at a production company in Los Angeles, then at a trade-show company, then at a security software firm. She had, by any measure, little to no experience in skin care, retail, or business.

Four years after she started selling that soap. An imported bar cleanser she had discovered through a friend. Masterson launched Drunk Elephant. Six years after that, in October 2019, the Japanese cosmetics conglomerate Shiseido acquired her company for $845 million.[38]



Let that number sit for a moment. Eight hundred and forty-five million dollars. For a skincare brand founded by someone whose professional background included zero hours of clinical training, zero hours of dermatological research, and zero hours of cosmetic chemistry education. The purchase price represented more than eight times Drunk Elephant's 2018 revenue. More than twenty times its earnings.

"I started this business as an industry outsider, and from the beginning I did things a little differently."

Tiffany Masterson, Founder of Drunk Elephant[38]

She did. But here's what's interesting: so did Pat McGrath.

Pat McGrath is, by any reasonable measure, the most accomplished makeup artist alive. She has led backstage teams at Alexander McQueen, Dior, Prada, and Louis Vuitton. British Vogue once called her "the most influential makeup artist in the world." In 2015, she launched Pat McGrath Labs. A luxury cosmetics line built on decades of expertise and specifically formulated with inclusive shade ranges for melanated skin.

In 2018, the same year Drunk Elephant was generating roughly $100 million in revenue, Pat McGrath Labs received an investment from French private equity firm Eurazeo that valued the company at over $1 billion. A Black woman with unparalleled professional credentials had built a billion-dollar brand. The system, it seemed, could work.[25]

> **Except it didn't.**

The woman with no expertise built a company worth $845 million. The woman with more expertise than almost anyone in her field watched her billion-dollar valuation evaporate.

> This is not a story about talent. It's a story about what the beauty industry actually values and who it doesn't.

The Aesop Paradox: A $2.53 Billion Lesson in Who Gets Valued

In April 2023, L'Oréal announced its largest acquisition in 110 years of corporate history: Aesop, the Australian skincare brand, for $2.53 billion.

The deal completed that August. The deal crystallised everything the beauty industry claims to value and everything it actually does.[36]

Read the acquisition commentary carefully. On completion, L'Oréal's chief executive Nicolas Hieronimus celebrated Aesop's "unique combination of urbanity, hedonism and undeniable luxury," a brand that "taps into all of today's ascending currents."[36] Analysts highlighted the brand's "large male customer base," its "resonance in Asian markets," its potential for expansion in China where the first store had only opened in 2022. Business of Fashion noted three qualities that made Aesop irresistible: male customers, company-owned retail stores, and Asian market appeal.

Absent from every press release, every analyst note, every business publication's coverage: any mention of how Aesop's products perform on melanin-rich skin. Any acknowledgment that the brand's formulations, like Le Labo's, like Byredo's are predominantly water-based. Any consideration of whether the $2.53 billion valuation reflected a brand that serves all consumers or merely the consumers L'Oréal cares about reaching.

Now compare valuations:

Aesop: $2.53 billion, with $537 million in 2022 sales. Acquisition multiple: approximately 4.7 times revenue.

Carol's Daughter: Acquired by L'Oréal in 2014 for $27 million, when the brand had $27 million in annual sales. Acquisition multiple: 1 time revenue.

Both were L'Oréal acquisitions. Both were positioned as prestige brands with devoted followings. The difference: one was founded by a white Australian man and marketed to aesthetes; the other was founded by a Black American woman and served Black consumers.

And maybe that’s it. Maybe this is what I've been missing all along. This article was the one where it all came together and became crystal clear.

The beauty industry, in a majority of the products on the gleaming shelves, does not serve all and sundry. They know that and neither do they care.

But they do know who they wish to serve.

Aesop received a valuation 4.7 times its sales. Carol’s Daughter received a valuation equal to its sales. Same acquirer. The maths speaks for itself.

The valuation disparity reveals the industry’s actual priorities with mathematical precision. When L’Oréal acquires a brand, it assigns value based on perceived growth potential, market positioning, and strategic fit.

Aesop's $2.53 billion reflected L'Oréal's belief that the brand could expand dramatically in China and beyond. Carol's Daughter's $27 million reflected... what, exactly? That serving Black consumers caps your ceiling? That expertise in melanin-rich skin formulation commands no premium? That brands built by Black founders for Black consumers will never achieve the multiples awarded to brands built by others?

The maths is damning though it is worth being careful about whose maths it is. According to Natura, Aesop's gross sales grew from $28 million in 2012 to $537 million in 2022, a nineteen-fold increase, with stores rising from 52 to 395. Contemporaneous reporting put the starting point rather higher: at the time of the 2012 deal Aesop was described as operating more than 60 stores in eleven countries on sales of around $67 million, with A$64 million forecast for the financial year ending June 2013.

On those figures the growth is closer to eightfold. The nineteen-fold version appeared in the announcement of a $2.5 billion sale.[42]Either

way, the growth story drove the valuation. Black-founded brands demonstrate comparable or superior growth rates when funded. McKinsey's research shows they outperform non-Black brands funded in the same cohorts. But they don't receive comparable funding, so they can't demonstrate comparable scale, so they don't command comparable valuations.
The cycle ensures Black founders remain undervalued regardless of their actual performance.

Case Study: The Exception That Proves the Rule

In July 2020, Rihanna launched Fenty Skin.

The announcement was not subtle. The brand's marketing materials stated, explicitly, that "every Fenty Skin product was tested on all skin tones, textures, and types."[39] The SPF moisturiser was formulated to be "truly invisible on all skin tones"
No white cast, no chalky residue. The cleanser was designed for the sensitivities that women of colour commonly experience. The entire line was, from its inception, built around the principle that diverse skin is not an afterthought.



This was not Rihanna's first venture into beauty. In 2017, she had launched Fenty Beauty with LVMH's Kendo Brands division. A makeup line that debuted with forty foundation shades, nearly double the industry standard.

The launch sparked what observers would later call "the Fenty Effect": within months, Maybelline expanded its Fit Me line from sixteen to forty shades. CoverGirl launched TruBlend with forty shades. Dior released its Backstage collection with forty shades. An entire industry pivoted because one brand had demonstrated that serving diverse consumers was not charity. It was commerce.

Fenty Beauty generated more than €500 million in revenue in its first full year. By 2021, Forbes valued the brand at $2.8 billion and confirmed that Rihanna's 50 percent stake had made her a billionaire. Primarily through cosmetics, not music.[26]

The success is undeniable. But there is something troubling in the story, something that becomes clear only when you ask the right question: Why did it take Rihanna?

Rihanna is one of the most famous people on Earth. She has 160 million Instagram followers. She had a 50/50 partnership with LVMH, the largest luxury conglomerate in the world. She had resources. Financial, cultural, institutional that almost no other founder could access.

And she needed all of it. She needed the fame, the platform, the backing of a global luxury empire, just to insist on something that should have been obvious: that skincare products should work for all skin tones.

Fenty Skin's approach. Testing across the full Fitzpatrick scale, formulating for diverse needs, treating inclusion as a baseline. Is not revolutionary science. It is basic competence. Any brand could do it. Any brand could have done it decades ago.

But they didn't. Not until a billionaire celebrity with LVMH backing forced the issue.

This is what the Fenty story actually reveals: the industry knew how to serve diverse consumers. It always knew. The science existed. The formulation techniques existed. The testing methodologies existed. What didn't exist was the will.

It took Rihanna. Her fame, her resources, her leverage. To make inclusion mandatory. And even then, even after the Fenty Effect rippled through the industry, even after every major brand scrambled to expand its shade range, the fundamental economics remained unchanged.

Topicals still couldn't raise the capital it needed. Pat McGrath Labs still collapsed. Ami Colé still closed its doors.[8][25][40][41]

> **The exception did not change the rule. It illuminated it.**

The Expertise Problem: Who Gets to Formulate, Who Gets to Sell

There exists a profound asymmetry in who the beauty industry considers qualified to create skincare products versus who actually possesses relevant expertise.

Ben Gorham, former basketball player, fine art graduate: qualified to launch a skincare line. Jérôme Epinette, perfumer: qualified to extend fragrance brands into skincare. Fashion designers, celebrities, influencers with no scientific training: qualified to launch skincare brands that command premium shelf space and retail partnerships.

Dr. Shereene Idriss, board-certified dermatologist, built a following of nearly a million people on social media before launching a skincare line in 2022.

Self-funded, direct to consumer, with a co-founder from L'Oréal's marketing side. It sold out repeatedly. Sephora took the range exclusively two years later.[43] AJ Addae, cosmetic chemist, left a formulation job over what she has described as the deprioritisation of Black skin in its research, and founded Sula Labs on a $5,000 grant.

Products she formulates now sit on shelves in Sephora, Ulta and Target under other brands' names.[44] Both succeeded. Note the route. Neither was funded into the market by the institutions that should have recognised what they knew; each had to build the way in herself, one through an audience, one through her own laboratory. The industry does not block clinical expertise so much as decline to pay for it, and then buy the results once someone else has taken the risk.

The disparity is not in who eventually succeeds. It is in what each of them had to bring before anyone would listen. A fragrance house extending into skincare needs existing brand equity and nothing else. No clinical evidence, no testing data, no dermatologist on staff. A celebrity needs an audience. A board-certified dermatologist with a decade of clinical practice needs, it turns out, an audience as well.

The credential itself buys nothing. It is not a currency this industry trades in. What it trades in is brand recognition, Instagram reach, the ability to generate press coverage, and alignment with existing retail relationships. A basketball player with good taste arrives already holding those assets. A cosmetic chemist has to manufacture them from scratch, alongside the actual science.

The credentialism runs one direction only.

When a fragrance house extends into skincare, existing brand equity suffices; nobody asks Byredo for clinical data. When celebrities launch lines, retailers compete for the exclusive. When Black founders launch skincare brands, investors demand proof of concept, clinical evidence and demonstrated market traction and the funding figures set out earlier in this piece show what happens to the ones who supply it.

> **When the people formulating your skincare don’t understand your skin, and the industry rewards them anyway, the message is unmistakable: your skin isn’t the priority. Your money is.**

NEXT IN THE SKINCARE INVESTIGATION

06 - The Shelf Space Struggle

Expertise can be ignored; distribution cannot. Next, the investigation moves to the retail floor. Where shelf space, buyer assumptions and the economics of "niche" decide which brands consumers are allowed to find.

A Note on Method

The body of this article is selected from the original skincare investigation. The wording has been preserved; the editing lies in what has been included and where the article ends. The series label, subtitle, section packaging and "Next" bridge are editorial additions.

Product, ingredient, company and market information cited here was drawn from manufacturers' own pages and the research sources recorded in the master document. Formulations, company information and product guidance can change; readers should compare any current label or company disclosure with the material discussed here.

Source Notes

[8] Diarrha N'Diaye-Mbaye, personal essay, The Cut (New York Magazine), 17 July 2025. Revenue growth figure per the BOLD investment announcement, September 2024, reported in Cosmetics Business, 18 July 2025. Carol Hamilton quoted in Women's Wear Daily, 20 September 2024.

[25] Pat McGrath Labs: Eurazeo Brands invested $60m in 2018 at a valuation above $1bn and exited in 2021; Sienna Investment Managers wrote down its stake by 88%, implying c.€149m ($174m). Chapter 11 filed 22 January 2026, US Bankruptcy Court, Southern District of Florida — reported by Women's Wear Daily, 26 January 2026; see also Beauty Independent and Business of Fashion.

[26] LVMH annual report 2018 (Fenty Beauty first-year revenue); Forbes, "Fenty's Fortune: Rihanna Is Now Officially A Billionaire," 4 August 2021.

[33] Byredo Suede Hand Lotion and Blanche Hand Cream ingredient listings, byredo.com; cross-checked against INCIDecoder. Accessed July 2026.

[34] Celia Shatzman, “Ben Gorham On Going From Basketball To Byredo And Disrupting The Beauty World,” Forbes, 29 June 2021.

[35] Estée Lauder acquisition of Le Labo announced 15 October 2014; terms undisclosed. Price and sales estimates per Women’s Wear Daily, reported in Crain’s New York Business, 15 October 2014.

[36] L’Oréal press release, “L’Oréal completes acquisition of Aesop,” 30 August 2023. The 3 April 2023 announcement used the phrasing “a superb combination.”

[38] Shiseido Company, Limited, press release, “Shiseido to Acquire DRUNK ELEPHANT,” 8 October 2019.

[39] Fenty Skin launch press release, “Rihanna Launches Fenty Skin,” PR Newswire, 31 July 2020.

[40] Olamide Olowe, interview with Beauty Independent, 4 September 2025.

[41] Olamide Olowe, interview with The Business of Beauty (Business of Fashion), January 2026.

[42] Natura &Co announcement of the sale of Aesop to L’Oréal, 3 April 2023 ($28m–$537m; 52–395 stores; 8–29 markets). Contemporaneous figures per BeautyMatter, 31 January 2023 ($67.4m sales, 60-plus stores in 11 countries at acquisition) and Premium Beauty News, January 2013 (A$64m forecast for FY ending June 2013).

[43] Dr Shereene Idriss / PillowtalkDerm launch: Women’s Wear Daily, 19 September 2022; Forbes, 19 September 2022. Sephora exclusive: Marie

Claire, March 2024.

[44] AJ Addae and Sula Labs: Girls United (Essence), 2024; Northeastern University News, 10 July 2024; BeautyMatter, 5 February 2026; UCLA Department of Chemistry, Black Ambition Grand Prize announcement.

ABOUT THIS RESEARCH

Diversity in Crisis: *The Skincare Investigation*

A six-part investigation into how the beauty industry's promises on inclusion compare with what it actually does, written by Boyowa Olugbo, Managing Director of Praxis Brands.

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02	The Skin Skincare Forgot to Study	PUBLISHED 30 AUGUST 2026
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How it is researched

Factual claims carry numbered notes. Ingredient lists are taken from manufacturers' own published information, with the date accessed recorded, and cross-checked against at least two independent sources. A claim that rests on a single source is removed rather than qualified.

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Write to boyowa@praxisbrands.co.uk with what you think is wrong and, where you can, the evidence. We will check it, correct the research if we got it wrong, and record the correction at praxisbrands.co.uk/research.

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